

ONE MAN'S OPINION

Girard Had Poor Point of View
For Call on Fans Interference

By RAYMOND JOHNSON



Leave it to Charlie Hurth's "Pore Boys" to come up with a new one . . . They did in Sulphur Dell yesterday when they ruled interference by a spectator in the stands.

This unusual play occurred in the fifth inning with the singling Bobby Durnbaugh on first base and none out . . . George Schmees hit a foul that the wind caught and it drifted into the stands, almost directly opposite third base.

A front row spectator, apparently trying to get a souvenir baseball, hit the ball and knocked it from the outstretched hand of Pel Third Baseman Vern Piver . . . Umpire Bill Melvin, behind the plate, ruled it a foul.

Girard Made Ruling After Being Consulted

Then Andy Cohen, the New Orleans skipper, rushed to the plate and claimed interference . . . After making his case, Andy suggested that Frank Girard, the senior umpire of the team be consulted . . .

And Girard, who had been near second base when Schmees hit the ball, promptly ruled George was out because of "interference by a spectator."



Gail Henley

The only time spectator interference can legally be called is when a spectator is on the playing field or reaches out of the stands to prevent a player from making a catch . . . From my perch high in the press box it was obvious the ball was in the stands . . . Even after being touched by the spectator, it hit on the railing in front of the seats.

Andy Cohen had an argument since he could not tell whether the ball was in the stands or not from his position . . . And he was in no better position to call it than was Girard . . . Melvin was in a much better position than either . . . He passed the buck . . . He called Schmees out after Girard's ruling.